

tions aren't always spot on, but gives you a chance to discover new blogs and Web sites in your line of interest.

The Trends tab gives you analysis of your own reading habits — which blogs are the most read, a bar chart showing the ratio of posted items and items read by you, along with data on the daily frequency of posts from sources. It seems like useless trivia — “From your 37 subscriptions, over the last 30 days you read 329 items, starred 4 items, shared 1 items, and emailed 0 items” Google Reader tells us. The cool thing about having Google analyse your reading habits is that the Home tab generates a list of unread items based on the data collected, so your favourite news sources are prioritised over other subscription feeds that aren't so hot.

If your phone has a data connection, you can access Google Reader on the go by pointing your mobile phone's browser to: <http://www.google.com/reader/m>. You can even configure your Google Reader for offline use by installing the Google Gears plugin, or using the Google Chrome browser. This feature enables you to read up to 2,000 items even when your computer is not connected to the Internet. For those with iffy broadband, it's quite a blessing.

Keyboard shortcuts make Google Reader more convenient to use — every operation that can be performed with the mouse also has an assigned keyboard shortcut: (www.google.com/help/reader/faq.html#shortcuts) try this one out: press the “t” button to tag an item, and “gt” to have an Ajax panel popup, so you can search the feeds by tags.

Google's offerings are constantly upgraded, with new features added based on customer feedback. They just added a killer feature — automatic translation from any language, a feature not yet present in any other feed reader. As far as Web apps go, this one is the best.

Rating: ★★★★★

Bloglines

URL: www.bloglines.com

Price: Free

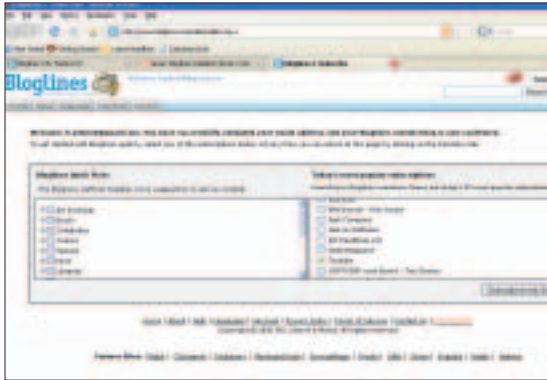
Launched in 2003, Bloglines is one of the oldest Web-based news aggregators around, and it still commands loyalty. It is by no means, old school — in fact, compared to Google Reader, it has plenty more features to manage news, reduce spam, and share breaking news.

Once you sign up for the service, you're presented with a list of suggestions from the Bloglines staff — the 50 most popular subscriptions, feeds by category — Music, News, Politics, Sports, Technology, etc. For a newbie, this is a good way to start off, though you'll only find news sources that are heavily leaning towards what's happening in the West. You can import an OPML file to quickly setup your subscriptions — we were able to import our lists of Web feeds from Google Reader.

The interface is not much to look at — the Web site looks like a relic from the pre-web 2.0 era, which can be remedied somewhat by using their beta Web site at beta.bloglines.com. The new beta interface has a start page, a three-panel reading view, and supports drag and drop feed management.

There's a neat Blogroll feature that lets you export your Bloglines subscriptions with a wizard that generates HTML for your blog. You can also configure your account so that other readers can view your subscriptions on the Bloglines Web site: (bloglines.com/public/yourUserID). Bloglines has a built-in blog application that can take news from

Bloglines lets new users select from a wide choice of popular RSS feeds.



your RSS feeds, and save them as clippings, so you can add your notes and thoughts to that article and publish it. It's rudimentary and lacks the shine and finish of other blogger software, but it's effective. Because it's a Web-based app, it can use the information collected from its user base to recommend feeds to you.

Bloglines is also backwards compatible with the predecessor to RSS feeds — Newsletters.

It's really useful — you can create a temporary bloglines email account and use it to subscribe to any service that forces you to register with an email account. If you unsubscribe from a service / software, the bloglines email account is deleted, and anyone who tries to spam you will be spamming a dead email account. You spare your email address all the possible spam you might incur.

Another cool feature from Bloglines: you can enter the tracking numbers for UPS, FedEx, and DHL deliveries, and receive updates on the status of your package.

You can download a small program that notifies you whenever you have new items in your Bloglines account. The Notifier works with Windows, Mac OSX, and some Linux brews. It also works with browsers — and can be installed as an extension on IE or Mozilla Firefox.

While Bloglines is a compelling application with plenty of features, the quality of its uptime is a concern, many of its core users have been complaining that a lot of feeds don't get updated; the problem has been acknowledged by Bloglines too. Bloglines syncs with desktop-based clients like Snarfer (reviewed later) and RSS Bandit, so you do not have to use their Web interface at all times. Migrating from Bloglines shouldn't be a problem, should you have issues with feed updates. Bloglines may not have the keyboard friendliness of Google Reader, but has a few useful keyboard shortcuts, and is still worth a look.

Rating: ★★★★★

Desktop Feed Readers

Browser-based RSS Feed readers can only do so much — with broadband quality being so undependable at the present time, having a client-based feed reader gives you the ability to download feeds and read them at your leisure. Client-based feed readers can handle hundreds of feeds, and if you want to run searches on them, some even provide an offline mode where they cache all the feeds; others run persistent queries on Ebay and Craigslist, download and sync your podcasts on your MP3 player, and more. Best of all, some of the feed readers mentioned below can synchronise with an online feed reader — Google Reader, NewsGator. com, or Bloglines.

NewsGator FeedDemon 2.7

Web site: www.newsgator.com

Price: Free

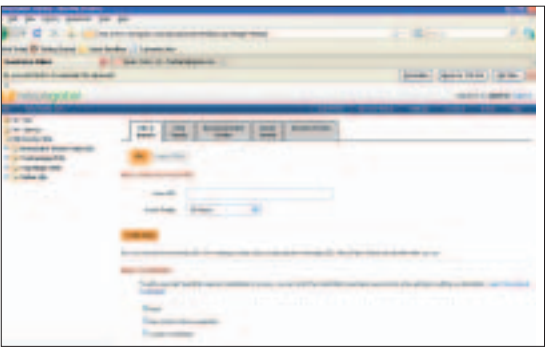
Size: 3.9 MB

Feed Demon from NewsGator is designed for those who need to digest an enormous amount of news in a little time. NewsGator used to charge for its desktop reader, but starting with FeedDemon 2.6, the company started offering the desktop client for free. The latest version has many cool features not found in other clients — synchronisation, an offline read mode, streaming video support, and desktop alerts.

The install is a measly 4 MB, and configuring the software is easy, thanks to wizards that recommend a list of feeds to start with, and the ability to import OPML files. The application has a neat and intuitive two-pane interface which supports tabbed browsing, and uses the default browser's rendering engine to display the Web pages when you click on an article.

FeedDemon also offers a browser-based version of the app on NewsGator online, in case you need to browse on a different computer. We tested this feature out, and while it kept a proper read count of the feeds, it was unable to delete folders and old feeds that

Too much news? Hit the panic button to prune your reading list



we had removed in the client version. And since this is proprietary software, it doesn't have an option of syncing with Google Reader, if that's your Web app of choice. There are other apps which can do that — like Snarfer and RSS Bandit.

The application has a 'Prefetch for offline reading mode' that downloads all your feeds so you can read them at your leisure — a very useful feature for those with limited Internet access. This gives you the ability to read all your subscriptions in a train or a flight, without Internet access. When you're online, the software can minimise to tray and provide alerts when new stories arrive.

FeedDemon gives you the ability automatically to download podcasts and video feeds from Web sites. The bundled FeedStation automatically syncs with iTunes and devices running Windows Media Player 10 or greater.

FeedDemon's Watches are like filters that provide a new way to search through your feeds — if you add a watch for “HDTV” for example, every feed entry containing the word will be stored in the Watch, and any new breaking stories with the words “HDTV” will be added to the Watches list. The Clippings feature helps you store relevant news stories in an easily accessible location, for future reference.

You can subscribe to a feed based on keywords as well — similar to Google Alerts. Whether you are monitoring a breaking news story, celebrity, or a competitor, this allows you to select a feed search engine (Google News, Del.icio.us, Flickr, Google Blog, Google News) and automatically



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